

**The invasion of India**
Mughal cavalry ride into battle during Akbar's invasion of India in the 1560s. The Mughals came originally from present-day Afghanistan, but the army that Akbar and subsequent Mughal emperors created incorporated warriors from across Central Asia and the Indian subcontinent.

AT THE HEIGHT OF THEIR POWER in the 16th and 17th centuries, the Mughal emperors of India commanded far larger armed forces than any contemporary European power could have mustered. Like their fellow Muslims, the Ottoman Turks, they combined the Central Asian cavalry tradition of the Mongols and Tartars with the use of cannon and firearms. Their weaknesses were a failure to appreciate the effectiveness of disciplined infantry and the lack of a coherent command structure to direct their unwieldy and multi-ethnic army.

Babur, the founder of the Mughal Empire, was a Turco-Mongol descendant of the much-feared conqueror Timurlane. As the chief of a band of Muslim warriors, or *ghazis*, he conquered Kabul in Afghanistan in 1504 and from 1516 began raiding south into India. His defeat of Sultan Lodi of Delhi at Panipat in 1526 allowed him to establish his rule in northern India. The empire was not settled on a solid basis, however, until the reign of Akbar (ruled 1556–1605). An active military campaigner, Akbar extended the area of India under Mughal control and integrated warriors from varied backgrounds, Muslim and Hindu, into a large-scale imperial army.

## IMPERIAL ARMY

The army Akbar created kept contact with the Mughals' Central Asian roots. The emperor recruited nomadic warbands into his army, attracting them with the prospect of a share in the empire's wealth. They included large contingents of Turanis, originating from Central Asia. These were horsemen especially skilled in the use of the composite bow, who were bound to their warband leader by the simple principle of fidelity to the man whose food they ate. Iranis and Afghanis – the latter noted both for their fierceness and their unreliability – also came south to serve the empire. But Akbar and subsequent emperors also integrated into their forces the warriors of each area of India that they conquered. Thus for example the Rajputs, renowned Hindu military aristocrats, brought their followers into the service of the Mughals. The Rajputs espoused a chivalric code of honour that valued close combat man-to-man and despised missile warfare. They also stressed self-sacrifice and the choice of death rather than dishonour. The more pragmatic Mughals are reported to have felt the Rajputs "knew how to die but not how to fight", but they welcomed the cavalry and armed peasantry that Hindu warriors brought to the army.

## AMIRS AND HOUSEHOLD FORCES

The warlords and nobles who brought their followers to serve the emperor were designated "amirs". As well as status in the court hierarchy, they received money from the Mughal treasury to pay their men and the right to raise revenue from provinces placed under their control. There were several hundred amirs at any given time, with around 100,000 to 200,000 retainers. As well as these troops, the emperor had household forces under his direct control. These consisted of a few thousand cavalry and musketeers, added to large quantities of artillery and a substantial number of war-elephants. Surprisingly, though, he did not have any soldier-slaves, a major feature of contemporary Muslim armies in Turkey, Egypt, and Iran.

The function of the Mughal army was to maintain and extend the emperor's rule in the Indian subcontinent. The emperor was never close to establishing a monopoly of armed force within his own domains. As one observer commented, with reference to the widespread distribution of matchlock muskets, "even the cultivator at the time of ploughing has his loaded gun fastened to the plough, and his match burning". It has been calculated that in the late 16th century the Mughal Empire contained over four million armed men.



**TURBAN HELMET WITH NASAL AND NECK GUARD**